

Narrative Crossroads: The Most Dangerous Game

A character analysis framework for exploring key decisions and motivations

Overview

This module adapts the Narrative Crossroads framework for analyzing Richard Connell’s “The Most Dangerous Game.” Students write in character as either Rainsford or General Zaroff at critical moments in the story, writing from inside those moments and comparing readings afterward.

Setting Context

- **Time Period:** Early 20th century
- **Location:** Ship-Trap Island in the Caribbean
- **Social Context:** Post-World War I era, colonial mindset, big game hunting culture
- **Atmosphere:** Isolated, threatening, primordial

Character Options

Choose, or roll a die.

Roll	Character	What they want	What they fear
1–3	Rainsford	To survive, and to stay the kind of man he believes he is	Becoming the animal he has always hunted
4–6	General Zaroff	A quarry that can reason — a hunt worth having	Boredom, and being ordinary

Threshold Moments

Choose, or roll a die. Everyone works the same moment.

Roll	Threshold Moment	Why it is a threshold
1–2	Falling overboard	Surviving the swim to shore; and Deciding whether to call out upon seeing lights
3–4	Discovering Zaroff hunts humans	Recognizing Zaroff’s hidden meaning; and Deciding how to respond
5–6	Being hunted	Creating traps and defenses; and Anticipating Zaroff’s strategy

The Three Lenses

Everyone works from the same character at the same threshold moment. Each student takes one lens — pick, or roll a die so the room spreads across all three. The die only chooses the way in; nothing is rolled against a character, and there is nothing to succeed or fail at.

Roll	Lens	What it asks at this moment
1–2	Confrontation	A clash. What are you up against, and what does facing it cost?
3–4	Comprehension	A realization. What do you understand now that you didn't a moment ago?
5–6	Connection	The bonds. Who is this really about, and what do you owe them?

Then write a few sentences in the character's voice, at that moment, showing one thing from the character's wants or fears. The writing is the play.

Thematic Elements

- The hunter versus the hunted
 - Civilization versus savagery
 - The value of human life
 - The ethics of sport and hunting
 - Predator and prey psychology
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Implementation Guide

Classroom Setup (45–60 minutes)

1. **Introduction (5 min):** Explain the round and distribute cards
2. **Character Selection (5 min):** Students choose a character, or roll a die for one
3. **Threshold Moment (5 min):** The teacher frames one moment for the whole room
4. **Evidence (10 min):** Students fill the Character Frame — what this character wants and fears, with a line or page number
5. **Take a lens and write (15–20 min):** Students take a lens and write in character
6. **Harvest (10–15 min):** Read several aloud, at least one per lens, then ask which reading the text supports

Materials Needed

- A die per table, if you want to assign lenses by chance rather than choice. It is optional; students can simply pick.
 - Character Frame cards
 - Copy of the text
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Assessment Options

- **Character Journal:** Students submit written responses from the character's perspective
 - **Audio Character Study:** Students record their written response, read aloud in character
 - **Comparative Analysis:** Students compare readings of the same moment across lenses
 - **Alternate Ending:** Students craft an ending that would follow from their reading
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ELA Standards Alignment

- **RL.9-10.1** — Cite strong and thorough textual evidence to support analysis
 - **RL.9-10.3** — Analyze how complex characters develop, interact with other characters, and advance the plot
 - **W.9-10.3** — Write narratives with well-developed characters and event sequences
 - **SL.9-10.1** — Initiate and participate effectively in collaborative discussions
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Sample Response

Character: Rainsford

Threshold Moment: Being hunted — the moment when Rainsford must decide how to counter Zaroff's pursuit.

Lens: Confrontation

What they wrote:

Drawing on your extensive hunting experience, you construct a Malay man-catcher—a weighted log attached to a trigger. The work is precise and methodical despite your exhaustion and the growing darkness. Each time you hear distant sounds of pursuit, your hands work faster, but you maintain the careful attention to detail that has kept you alive on countless hunts. As you put the finishing touches on the trap, you allow yourself a moment of grim satisfaction. You've transformed from hunted to hunter, setting the stage for your pursuer to become the pursued. The trap isn't just a physical defense; it's a psychological statement—evidence that Zaroff has finally found the worthy prey he so desperately sought.

Version 3

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